



▲ FOUNTAINS IN THE GARDENS OF VILLA D'ESTE

## Palace of Charles V

**Location** Granada, Spain

The Holy Roman Emperor Charles V was the most powerful ruler in Europe, commanding a vast accumulation of territories across the continent, as well as in the Americas. In 1527, he commissioned a new palace in Granada. However, when work stopped in 1568, it was still incomplete. Nevertheless, it is a remarkable building—majestic and idiosyncratic. Its principal facade of only two stories consists of 18 bays flanking a wider entrance bay, with a pedimented door below and an arched window above. The ground floor is very heavily rusticated, while the upper floor is crowded with pilasters and windows. The astonishing courtyard features a vast and austere, circular, two-story colonnade—Doric below, Ionic above—with arcades on both levels.

## Villa d'Este

**Location** Tivoli, Italy

The significance of the Villa d'Este, created for the hugely wealthy Cardinal Ippolito II d'Este (1509–1572), lies as much in its gardens as in the villa itself. In the 16th century, for the first time since the Roman empire, a concerted effort was made to produce landscaped gardens on a major scale. The goal was to create a kind of idealized landscape, alive with allusions to the Classical past, filled with statues that were intended to delight and surprise. Above all, fountains—symbols of abundance—expressed this new vision. They abound at the Villa d'Este. The result was a kind of intellectually exuberant recasting of nature, spilling downward terrace after terrace.

## Selimiye Mosque

**Location** Edirne, Turkey

Completed in 1574, the Selimiye Mosque was designed by Sinan, the architect of the Süleymaniye Mosque in Istanbul (see p.336). He declared it his finest work. Again, bold masses, built up layer by layer, are deployed to startling effect, culminating in a vast, shallow dome that rears 138 ft (42 m) over the city. Four 272-ft- (83-m-) high minarets frame the entire structure. The breathtaking interior is simultaneously monumental and seemingly weightless. The dome is carried on eight vast piers that rise into huge arches. Outside and below them are further arches. Throughout, there is a rhythmically repeating series of small, round-headed windows through which light floods. The dome itself is a wonder of vividly precise decoration.

## El Escorial

**Location** Central Spain

The Escorial, more properly El Real Monasterio de San Lorenzo de el Escorial, completed in 1584, was built by Philip II of Spain as the palace of the kings of Spain. It is a daunting structure, a reflection of the power of not just Europe's richest ruler but also, after the Reformation, the Catholic Church's most implacable champion. At its heart is a church dedicated to St. Laurence, after whom the Escorial is named. The gridlike floor plan is claimed to represent the grill over which St. Laurence was said to have been martyred in the 3rd century CE. With its 4,000 rooms and 15 miles (24 km) of passages, the Escorial is a building that enshrines scale over any more obvious architectural virtues.

## Château de Fontainebleau

**Location** Fontainebleau, France

Fontainebleau was the favorite of the energetic King François I's vast architectural creations. Situated in the forest of Fontainebleau, southeast of Paris, from the 12th century it was the site of a royal hunting lodge. But from 1528, under the direction of Gilles Le Breton, François utterly transformed it. Although it has been added to by later French monarchs, today's building is essentially his. Its plan is nothing if not irregular. It features an asymmetric assemblage of wings, courtyards, and connecting blocks, all under steeply pitched roofs punctuated by turrets, towers, and chimneys. Inside, it is lavish to a fault, with the Galerie de François I containing the first major cycle of Renaissance frescoes in France. It sits in immense, precisely landscaped gardens.